Chicago Cubs and the Chicago White Sox without going to the stadium.

In the press box at Wrigley Field or wherever the Cubs were playing, a telegrapher tapped out a report in Morse code after each pitch and each play of the game. In Des Moines, I sat at a microphone across from another telegraph operator with a pair of earphones wrapped around his head.

After each play, he decoded a burst of dots and dashes from the stadium and typed out a few words that described the play and handed it to me through a slot in a sheet of glass separating the studio and the control room. I then described the play as if I'd been in the press box, even though the slip of paper might say only "Out 4 to 3"; four was second base and three was first, so it was a grounder to the second baseman who threw the batter out at first. It had to be done quickly because we weren't the only ones covering the game. Six or seven other stations were also broadcasting Cubs games, most of them live from the press box. Sometimes, people would try to compare my broadcast to the live broadcast, and they told me that I was able to keep up within a half a pitch of the game.

Between pitches and innings, there was usually a lot of dead time that I had to fill with anecdotes and descriptions of the players, the field, and the weather. I wish I could count the number of ways I managed to describe how the rays of the afternoon sun looked as they fell across the rim of Wrigley Field.

One summer's day—and this is a story that I've probably repeated more times in my life than any other—my imagination was tested to its maximum. The Cubs and St. Louis Cardinals were locked in a scoreless ninth-inning tie with Dizzy Dean on the mound and the Cubs' Billy Jurges at bat.

I described Dean winding up and releasing his pitch. Then Curly, our telegraph operator, shook his head and passed